

| By Lungami Zama |

After all the waiting, this mad month of football and friendships is finally here. Right here in Africa, inside glittering stadia, with Vuvuzelas filling the air with the sound of constipated elephants stuck in rush hour traffic.

June 11 will be forever etched in the hearts of South Africans in the country when the FIFA World Cup finally kicked off on our shores. It was scripted, surely, that all this anxiety would not be deflated by a single swish of a Latino boot, consigning an entire continent to doom and gloom after just 90 minutes. This was a day of relief in many ways, as so many had said it would never come. On the morning itself there was outpouring of emotion, well before people started thinking about South Africa's opening match against Mexico.

It was almost surreal to experience the genuine hope invested in the team, from the weirdest of sources. All over various network sites like Facebook, Twitter and Mixit (a South African chat site), the talk was about the big game. Businesses closed early, while others didn't even bother calling their staff into work. This had suddenly become the biggest game in the nation's history.

On the streets, cars were hooting from 6 am, drivers smiling and pedestrians dancing their way to wherever they were going. It was almost like the party had started long before the guests of honour had even pitched up.

As news filtered through of Nelson Mandela's great grand-daughter passing away in a car accident, it felt almost inevitable that the euphoria sweeping through the country be dampened with a dose of reality. As Africans, we have learnt to take the good with a fair dose of the bad. The downside of the untimely incident was that 'Madiba' would not sprinkle his magic touch on the opening game.

Alas, the show had to go on, and despite the shakiest of starts, Bafana Bafana stayed level. Whatever delusions of grandeur locals had about a fairytale start were wiped away by some devastating play by the Mexicans. Quite

The Surreal SCRIPT

With its share of surprises, tragedies and controversies, the first World Cup in Africa is unique in its own ways

how Bafana didn't go into half-time a few goals down, we will never know.

But just when the nation started to doubt, rising star Siphiwe Tshabalala tore the roof off Africa with a goal that will live forever in our memories. It was a thing of violent beauty, and suddenly the fairytale was back on. Of course the Mexicans had to throw a spanner in the works with a late equaliser. I recall jumping up as he struck it, and then ending on my knees as it bounced off the upright—and stayed out. The disappointment of not winning was quickly replaced by the realisation that we had played a quality side, and France's nervy draw with Uruguay meant all things were square. The

dream is still alive, and we will happily go through the full range of emotions in our next two games.

The first weekend has allowed us to soak in the fact that the world's best stars were all collected in our fair land. It is still surreal to think that Messi, Ronaldo and Rooney are feeling the cold just as much as we are—although the sheets in first class accommodation probably keep one a lot warmer than us mere mortals. It has been a mission trying to keep up with the endless supply of games, interviews and side issues that the World Cup brings. Or its surprises like the tournament favourite Spain to Switzerland, whom until then we had only known as the chocolate



AP Photo

IN A JOBURG PUB, IVORY COAST SUPPORTERS WATCH THEIR TEAM AT THE CUP; (RIGHT) SWITZERLAND HOLD THEIR GROUND AGAINST TOURNAMENT FAVOURITES SPAIN

The Vuvuzela may annoy the players but they should rather focus on taming the Jabulani—and that's not an African design.